AI EXPLAINED SIMPLY

Data Center Alley: why the AI cloud lives in Loudoun County, Virginia

The short version: fiber came first, then the networks, then the rules that let buildings go up fast.

The map in 5 steps

1. **1992 — Vienna, Virginia.** Engineers link local fiber networks into **MAE East**, the first commercial internet exchange point (where networks meet and swap traffic). *(Loudoun County; Wikipedia: MAE-East)*
2. **1996 — Ashburn.** AOL opens its global headquarters in Ashburn, Loudoun County. UUNet follows in 1998. *(Loudoun County)*
3. **1997 — half the world.** About half of the world's internet traffic passes through MAE East. *(Loudoun Economic Development)*
4. **1998 — into Loudoun.** The exchange moves to Loudoun. Networks want to sit next to other networks: fiber attracts fiber. *(Loudoun Economic Development)*
5. **2000 — built like offices.** The county's Zoning Administrator treats data centers like office buildings, so they can be built "by right" wherever offices are allowed. (By-right development was ended in 2025.) *(Loudoun County)*

The numbers today (Loudoun County, as of March 2026)

What	Figure
Data center buildings, existing or under construction	about 233
Ranking	highest concentration of data centers anywhere in the world
Property tax paid by data centers, FY2026	$1.2 billion, about 39% of the county budget

| Data center space permitted in 2025 alone | over 10 million square feet (a one-year record) |

| Distance Ashburn to the White House | about 42 km in a straight line |

Why here? The 4 reasons the county itself lists

- Early fiber and the internet exchange right next door.
- A reliable power grid.
- Close to Washington, D.C., federal agencies and a major airport (Dulles).
- A business-friendly permitting environment and a qualified workforce.

Words to know

- **Data center:** a building full of servers. Your AI chats, videos and cloud files run on machines like these.
- **Internet exchange point (IXP):** a place where many networks plug into each other to swap traffic directly.
- **By right:** a project allowed by the zoning rules, with no special public vote needed.

Sources

- Loudoun County, "Data Centers: The Loudoun Story": https://www.loudoun.gov/6408/Data-Centers-The-Loudoun-Story
- Loudoun Economic Development, "MAE-East Internet Exchange Point Moves to Loudoun": https://biz.loudoun.gov/timeline/mae-east-internet-exchange-point-moves-to-loudoun
- Wikipedia, "MAE-East": https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/MAE-East

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